aging director of a private firm that had been engaged to do pre- and post-exam work at the Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar Agra University since 2014, claimed that Pathak had taken a total of Rs 1.41 crore in bribes—15 per cent of the total amount—to clear his company's dues of Rs 9.76 crore (the V-C had additional charge of the university between January 2022 and September 2022).

Pathak's close aide, Ajay Mishra, was arrested on October 30. Another associate, Ajay Jain, was arrested on November 6. Denis has alleged that the bribe money was delivered to Mishra's residence at Khurram Nagar in Lucknow, as instructed by Pathak. The complainant says the delays in clearances, threats and bribes have left his company "on the verge of collapse".

The plagiarism allegations from 2018 actually date back to events that unfolded in 2009, when Pathak had applied for the V-C's post at the Uttarakhand Open University. Media reports from 2018 say former UGC member Dharmendra Yadav had red-flagged the issue after seeking out Pathak's CV under the Right to Information Act. But even after the hullabaloo, Pathak, at the time the V-C of Dr A.P.J. Abdul Kalam Technical University (AKTU), Lucknow, got a second term with then UP governor Ram Naik clearing his name on August 2, 2018.

Pathak, a PhD in computer science, had a great run with the V-C post despite the many allegations that cropped up against him. He held the top post at Uttarakhand Open University, Haldwani (2009-12), Vardhman Mahaveer Open Univer-

TELANGANA

LAW OF THE JUNGLE

By Amarnath K. Menon

On November 26, four days after Gutti Koya tribals hacked forest range officer (FRO) Ch. Srinivasa Rao to death, forest officials in Telangana made an extraordinary demand which the state government is likely to approve. They wanted firearms to secure the jungle, deal with forest-related crimes and for self-protection. State principal chief conservator of forests (PCCF) R.M. Dobriyal has already raised the pitch on the issue. In a video conference with his officers, the PCCF told the worried force that he was asking for the opening of 30 new forest stations, each with an 18-member team, firearms and patrol vehicles. And this would just be in the first phase.

The Telangana situation already has a precedent; Kerala has set up similar stations to keep tabs on forest land encroachers, prevent smuggling/ poaching and protect the wildlife. Apart from forest stations, the Telangana government is also planning a legislation to amend the existing Forest Act, close the loopholes on punishments meted out (currently many offences have provisions for bail). "The government is committed to the security and protection of forest officials," Dobriyal emphasised to assuage the apprehensions of his officers. He also urged frontline staff, who have been on strike since November 24, to rejoin work immediately, saying their grievances would be addressed.

Srinivasa Rao, the 2021 KVS Babu state gold medal winner for forest protection, was killed when his team was attacked by the Gutti Koya tribals in the Yerrabodu habitation in Kothagudem division of Bhadradri Kothagudem district, bordering Chhattisgarh and Andhra Pradesh while trying to stop them from clearing forest land. Though illegal, tribals do this to take up *podu* (slash-and-burn shift cultivation) where they plant rain-fed crops initially and then shift to paddy and cash crops depending on irrigation sources. "After the attack on a woman FRO in Kagaznagar in 2019, Chief Minister K. Chandrashekar Rao (KCR) had ordered the police to coordinate with forest officials during operations, but it has not been happening," rues M. Raja Ramana Reddy, general secretary, Telangana Forest Officers' Association.

Elsewhere in the state, tribals are up in arms demanding title deeds for lands on which they take up *podu* cultivation. This covers some 3,041 villages across 28 districts. The state is reluctant to grant it, worried that the forest cover would be



The forest officer's murder has got the force agitated while the tribals are up in arms over title deeds to the land